Terrorist Response Plan

Prepared by:
Orange County Fire Chiefs' Association
Orange County Fire Services
Operational Plan

I. INTENT

The purpose of the plan is to provide operational procedures and guidelines for Orange County fire agencies in response to terrorist incidents. The guidelines will assist in providing organization and continuity to multi-agency and multi-discipline operations. The plan is designed to support Law Enforcement as the "lead" agency in a terrorist incident.

The procedures are designed to transition from incidents which are not initially determined to be terrorist incidents, but begin as a multi-victim or mass casualty incident, fire, rescue, hazardous materials release, or other type of incident. The plan is consistent with standard ICS/SEMS organization, responsibilities, and procedures.

II. PROCEDURE

A. Definition Terrorism, international or domestic, is defined as "any unlawful use of force or violence against persons or property to intimidate or coerce a government, the civilian population, or any segment thereof, in furtherance of political or social objectives."

There are many types of terrorist acts, and the results of terrorism can range from a single low-profile incident to acts of "super violence" where the terrorist is targeting mass destruction of property, lives, or both. Fire service responders should be aware of some of the more common types, which include:

1. Airline Attacks
2. Assassinations
3. Bombings
4. Chemical, Biological, or Nuclear Attacks
5. Fire/Property Attacks
6. Infrastructure Attacks

B. Tactical Alert Phases - Modes of Operation

There are three tactical alert phases or modes of operation associated with a terrorist incident.

<u>Phase One: Potential Response/Threat Warning</u>
A threat has not been confirmed but is considered possible. Situation may escalate to an "imminent response" condition. Depending on law enforcement

intelligence, information may or may not provide early warning or pre-planning capability.
Phase One is a planning phase in anticipation of a terrorist act based on information received from a recognized public safety agency. This will generally be done on a local and county-wide basis and involves coordination with involved law enforcement agencies.

Phase One will be implemented based on information that a terrorist act is possible in the reasonably foreseeable future. If there has been pre-planning, the threatened act is treated as an “imminent response” and unified command is established.

Phase Two: Imminent Response/Early Warning
A threat has been made, or a device has been located, or the threat has been confirmed. The potential incident has escalated from a threat to a condition of certainty. Possible time limits have been determined or confirmed.

Phase Two may be implemented based on information that a terrorist act is likely to occur within a 24 to 48 hour period or is occurring in a neighboring jurisdiction and there is a high certainty that a similar threat also exists within the jurisdiction.

The response is pre-planned, and a unified command structure is in place with a common tactical plan. It may include such actions as apparatus redeployment or staging, increased staffing, and identification of staging areas or mobilization centers.

Phase Three: Immediate Response/No Warning
No warning: the device or incident is underway prior to any pre-notification and/or threats. Generally, these claims are made after the incident has occurred or while the incident is still in progress. The initial resource response may have been sent under normal operating procedures before a terrorist incident is known, or it may be the actual deployment of units according to the tactical plan.

All normal operations should be suspended in the impact areas. In conjunction with the responsible law enforcement agencies, a unified command will take over impact area operations. Branches, divisions, and groups should be formed as necessary, and all fire department responses into affected areas will be controlled by the appropriate command.

Phase Three will be implemented in the event of a terrorist act occurring within a local jurisdiction involving the response of local fire units to a terrorist incident under a mutual aid request.

C. Area Coordination and Mobilization Centers

Following initiation of a Phase Two or Three Tactical Alert, individual units may be assigned to staging areas or mobilization centers. Mobilization centers are regional resource pooling centers. Police, fire, public works, and other resources may be teamed up at these locations.

Until it has been confirmed that there is no longer a threat to responders, units will not drive through impact areas unless directed by the fire communications center or the ICP. Units already within affected areas should determine whether or not they are in peril and if immediate danger requires a rapid departure. Those units may be sent to a mobilization center.

The Operational Area Mutual Aid Coordinator will maintain a list of sites (a minimum of 3) suitable for mobilization centers. These sites will serve as an assembly point for resources gathering in preparation for a response within or outside of Orange County. The purpose of the mobilization center is to support a large incident or a number of incidents by collecting and preparing resources for a rapid and safe response.

1. Upon determination of a Phase Two Tactical Alert by any agency within the county, the Orange County Operational Area Coordinator will select an appropriate mobilization center and may, after consulting with all Nets, dispatch the following support resources:

   a. 1 Mobilization Center Manager
   b. 1 Base Camp Manager
   c. 2 Safety Officers
   d. 1 Rehabilitation Unit
   e. 1 Communications Vehicle with Technician
   f. 1 Command Vehicle
   g. 1 Medic Unit

2. The Mobilization Center Manager will be responsible for supervising all activities and staff at the mobilization center. The Mobilization Center Manager will report directly to the Operational Area Coordinator until advised otherwise.

3. Resources dispatched to the Area/County mobilization center will complete a "check in" process, be briefed on the current situation, be provided a communications plan, and receive a safety message and a unit inspection. Units should not be dispatched into an area that has not been declared “safe to enter”.
4. If the primary purpose of the mobilization center is to support activities within Orange County, then additional resources will be dispatched to provide food, fuel, sleeping accommodations, etc.

5. Units responding as mutual aid to incident areas outside Orange County will first be formed into groups at a designated location within the county. They may be provided with police escorts, depending on the situation. Responses may be made by designated secure routes. All responses in or around the actual impact area should be Code 2 unless the immediate situation dictates otherwise.

6. Responses to terrorist incidents apply to the fire service’s mission in the form of existing County-wide Fire and Rescue Mutual Aid Plans. Examples include Civil Disturbance, Mass Casualty, Hazardous Materials, High Rise and Urban Search and Rescue. Depending on the situation, any or all of the above operational plans may be used.

D. Tactical Alert Phases – Responsibilities

1. Phase One Tactical Alert
   At the declaration of a Phase One Tactical Alert, the ranking chief officer of the involved jurisdiction will convene staff as deemed necessary to evaluate the available intelligence reports and develop contingency plans for Phases Two and Three. In most cases, this will involve coordination with fire agencies county-wide. Close coordination during this phase is essential. In addition, all companies will do the following:

   a. Insure that each unit with assigned personal body armor has its full complement carried on the unit and in a readily accessible location.
   b. Prepare fire stations in a manner to be easily secured if the company is deployed.
   c. Instruct company officers to conduct tailboard safety sessions with all crew members to discuss Standard Operating Procedures for Civil Disturbance, Body Armor, Mass Casualty, Haz Mat, and general safety.

2. Phase Two Tactical Alert

When a Phase Two Alert is declared, in addition to the above items, the following should be done immediately:

a. Ranking On-Duty Chief Officer
Upon notification, begin the implementation of the response plan developed in Phase One. This may include but not be limited to:

- Increase staffing on selected units, consider Haz Mat, Mass Casualty, USAR, etc.
- Call-back or hold over personnel to meet staffing needs.
- Pre-identify or stage task forces. Make preparations for each task force to have a leader (battalion chief) and three closed cab engines. One engine should have remote-controlled elevated stream capability if possible, and one engine should be a paramedic engine or PAU with advanced life support (ALS) capability.
- Establish a strong line of communications with local law enforcement agencies and the adjacent fire departments.

b. Field Battalion Chiefs
Upon notification, begin the implementation of the response plan developed in Phase One. This may include but not be limited to:

- Remain in close contact with the ranking on-duty chief officer and/or the communications center to obtain the most current intelligence reports. Specific direction from each department will be made available as the various portions of the Phase One plan are implemented.
- Initiate contact with all on-duty company officers to insure that they are aware of the potential situation. Provide them with specific direction in order to implement the desired portions of the plan.
- Closely monitor all incidents within the outlined tactical area.

c. Company Officers
Upon notification, begin the implementation of the response plan developed in Phase One. This may include but not be limited to:

- Consider having all personnel wear safety equipment, such as a helmet and a wildland Nomex jacket or turnout coat, on all incidents. This will visually identify the wearer as a firefighter and offer additional protection.

- Whenever a unit is driving or operating in or near an impact area, a helmet and eye protection should be worn in addition to other appropriate safety gear, depending on the potential threat.
- Review the alert information to determine if the station is in an impact area. If it is, prepare for potential evacuation of the station. Consider having off-duty personnel take their turnout gear home so that they can go directly to an assigned location if a recall is necessary.
- Consider securing the station by closing and locking all exterior doors and gates; all window coverings should be drawn and closed; perimeter lights should be left on; personnel should not be near windows or in areas exposed to potential flying debris from an explosion.

d. Communications Centers

Upon notification, begin the implementation of the response plan developed in Phase One. This may include but not be limited to:

- Notify all senior chief officers for the jurisdictions involved and the communications center for the Orange County Operational Area Coordinator. A courtesy notification of the on-duty senior chief officers of adjacent jurisdictions should also be initiated.
- Direct all units in the field that are not on active incidents to return to quarters.
- Assign separate dispatch consoles and additional dispatchers during the incident.
- Develop a communications plan and assign separate tactical frequencies to major areas of the incident.

3. Phase Three Tactical Alert

When a Phase Three Tactical Alert is activated by the ranking chief officer, appropriate battalion chief, or dispatch supervisor, the following actions will be taken:

a. Ranking Chief Officer

Upon notification of a Level Three Tactical Alert, the following action should be initiated:

- Confirm the declaration of a Phase Three Tactical Alert. Ensure that the declaration is announced via simulcast over all active radio channels and sent as a priority message to all units with MDT's. The information should include a confirmation of the staging and incident

base locations as established by a field battalion chief or police agency and the established boundaries of the impact area.

- Identify the boundaries of the impact area and update as needed.
- Consider ordering selected fire units that operate within the perimeter of the impact area to move immediately to specified staging areas.
- Confirm and disseminate the location of the mobilization center(s). As the Operational Area Coordinator, the Orange County Fire Authority may assume responsibility for setting up a mobilization center if the incident(s) crosses local boundaries or involves multiple jurisdictions. When a center is opened, it will be staffed with 2 to 3 task forces consisting of three engines and a task force leader. They will be drawn from all fire agencies county-wide.
- Provide a full briefing for the jurisdictional chief officers.

b. Battalion Chiefs

Upon notification of a Level Three Tactical Alert, the following action should be initiated:

- If the primary terrorist incident(s) is occurring in your area, respond to the law enforcement command post. Obtain location from the dispatch center.
- Meet with representatives from the involved police agencies at the command post and participate in a unified command.
- Advise the ranking jurisdictional officer of the location of staging areas, base location, mobilization center, and communication links for fire resources.
- Initiate a roll call for the units in the affected area(s) once the ICP is set up. Normal dispatching into the impact area may be suspended based on the assessment of the situation and threat to human life.
- Identify units that are unaccounted for and their last known locations, and/or units that may require extraction from the impact area, based on the roll call.
- Submit the list to the law enforcement representative, and any pertinent information from the communications center. If a representative from law enforcement has not arrived at the command post, the information should be transmitted through the local communications center to the proper law enforcement agency.
- Collect and prioritize incident data for response as police protection for fire department elements becomes available, or as areas are confirmed as secure from danger and safe to enter.
- If your area is uninvolved, confirm receipt of the Phase Three Tactical Alert with your communications center.

- Assess the current situation and monitor events by radio and the media. A captain can be directed to continue this process in the event that the battalion is uncovered.
- Depending on the local situation, direct company officers to modify standard firefighting tactics and utilize a more cautious approach.

c. Company Officers
Upon notification of a Level Three Tactical Alert, the following action should be initiated:

- Answer the roll call. If in the impact area, be prepared to give an assessment of the conditions, current location of the unit, and status of personnel and station.
- If directed, relocate to a staging area or incident base in the most expeditious manner possible. This includes securing the station and may include bringing along any unmanned relief apparatus stored at the station.
- Use discretion when operating Code 3; use it only when the benefit of the lights and siren outweighs the attention caused, and possible panic.

E. General Terrorist Response Actions
There are several general steps that should be taken by all first responders when arriving at a possible terrorist incident.

1. Recognize that the incident could be terrorist in nature
2. Request the appropriate resources/agencies: OCIAC, OCSD Bomb Squad, FBI, OC Health, Haz Mat
3. Establish a safe perimeter or exclusion zone
4. Identify impact areas (areas of rescue or where victims could be located)
5. Identify the type of agent/s involved (explosive, chemical, biological)
6. Conduct evacuations
7. Establish site security
8. Perform search & rescue/extrication
9. Perform fire suppression or neutralize/mitigate the hazard, stabilize the incident
10. Perform medical treatment

11. Perform a cursory check for secondary devices
12. Conduct recovery operations

F. Fire Service Initial Terrorist Response Actions
The following basic list of response actions should be used by first responding fire officers.

1. Report on Conditions
   a) Establish a cautious approach, big picture, wide view of incident
   b) Note unusual conditions, vehicles, persons
   c) Identify incident type(s) – rescue, mass casualty, fire suppression, hazardous materials, building collapse, etc.
   d) Determine incident status - static/stable or escalating/expanding
   e) Assess collateral danger - structural, chemical, biological, fire, explosive, gunfire, etc.

2. Assess Risk to Personnel and Public
   a. Evacuate all persons in the impact area
      1) It may be necessary to leave non-ambulatory victims in the "Hot Zone"
   b. Announce "all units stage-away" until risk assessment is complete

3. Establish Command
   a) Announce the name of the incident and give the address (and company name if a business)
   b) Identify a safe ICP location as well as the ability to expand or relocate the ICP
   c) Establish communications - radio, cellular phone, pager, MDT, messenger
   d) Establish unified command - law enforcement, others as appropriate

4. Establish Safe Perimeter, Exclusion Zone
   a) Identify and advise the location of care and shelter center(s) for evacuees
   b) Identify and announce a safe staging area
   c) Identify and announce the best access

5. Develop Joint Incident Action Plan (IAP)
   a. Identify incident priorities based on type of emergency
   b. List Incident objectives and sequence of events – consider rescue, decontamination, extrication, medical treatment, fire suppression, hazardous materials, stand-by rescue teams, firefighter accountability, etc.
   c. Establish time frames, operation periods, critical decision point.

d. Identify health and safety issues pertaining to response personnel and the public
e. Identify the organization - consider span of control: sections, branches, divisions, functional groups
f. List organization assignments and tasks
g. Prepare a communications plan and medical plan
h. Obtain weather information
i. Prepare incident maps and traffic plans
j. Include specialist or technical representative information

6. Identify Resource Needs
   a. Alarms, strike teams, task forces, specialized equipment
   b. Medic units, ambulances
   c. Truck companies
   d. Technical/heavy rescue units
   e. Urban search and rescue teams
   f. Hazardous materials units
   g. Chief officers, Incident Management Teams (IMT), overhead
   h. Specialized equipment - air utilities, hand crews, dozers, skip loaders, cranes, foam tenders, shoring materials
   i. Other cooperating and participating agencies

7. Order Additional Resources
   a. Consider relief, multiple operational periods
   b. Consider Area, region, state, federal, private resources

G. Cooperating Agencies

There are cooperating agencies in both the public and private sector that play vital roles during responses to terrorist incidents. Some of the more common include

Public Agencies

1. Law Enforcement - Local Police, Sheriff's Bomb Squad, FBI, ATF, etc.
   a. Evacuation
   b. Traffic control
   c. Crowd control
   d. Hazardous devices
   e. Hostage negotiations
   f. Evidence collection
   g. Crime scene investigation
2. Health Care Agency
   a. ReddiNet/HEAR Net
   b. Biological/chemical

c. Radiological
d. Epidemiological
e. Hazardous waste

3. Public Works
   a. Heavy equipment
   b. Public utilities
   c. Debris removal
   d. Specialized equipment
   e. Barricades

4. Care & Shelter - Local & County HCA, Red Cross
   a. Reception, care, and shelter of displaced persons

Private Agencies:

1. Utilities
   a. Water companies
   b. Gas companies
   c. Electric companies
   d. Sanitation districts/companies
   e. Cable television
2. Other
   a. Private property owners
   b. Business occupants/owners
   c. Business alliance

H. EMS Component

This policy will guide emergency medical operations during incidents involving terrorist activities. The very nature of operating in an area of a terrorist incident may require a deviation from established Orange County Emergency Services protocols.

While operating under a Phase Three Tactical Alert, the jurisdictional fire department IC may request the responsible Communications Center to activate the Mass Casualty Incident Response Plan (Declare an MCI) for a specific impact area. The request is made per Orange County EMSA Policy/Procedure #900.00. This will produce the following results:

1. The paramedics operating in the declared impact zone will be exempt from the radio contact portion of their normal protocol, allowing them to operate on standing orders.
2. The hospital "ReddiNet" system will be activated through Base Hospital and a coordinated approach can be used to assign patients to hospitals

out of the area affected by the civil disturbance.

3. All patients transported out of the impact area will be taken to a hospital assigned by the incident medical branch in coordination with the MedComm.
4. A medical branch will be established as soon as possible and staffed with a qualified branch director. Once established, the Branch Director will work with the Operations Section Chief to staff the branch to the level of incident need and coordinate medical operations. The responsibilities of the branch include:
   a. Insure that adequate ground ambulances are available for the incident.
   b. Request an ambulance company representative at the command post if necessary.
   c. Identify an ambulance staging area and appoint a manager.
5. Coordinate with the Incident Operations Chief who will form up appropriately configured EMS response groups.
   a. Staff a Medical Communications Coordinator (MedCom) at the Incident Communications Unit.
   b. Designate patient transportation routes.
   c. Coordinate with the Air Operations Branch Director if air ambulances are used.
   d. Provide a Communications Plan to MedCom and the Incident Dispatch.
6. Medical assistance requests from within the impact area will be routed as follows:
   a. Requests from incident personnel or any communications center will be directed to the Incident Communications Unit
   b. The Medical Branch Director or his designee will prioritize the request, assign the appropriate resource configuration (based on type and location of the request) and direct the Incident Communications Unit to dispatch the units. The Branch Director should remain at the Incident Communications Unit.
   c. MedCom will coordinate, through the Base Hospital assigned by OCC to determine receiving center locations, and through the Branch Director to determine safe routes of travel.
   d. Responding units will communicate with the MedCom on a predesignated channel for hospital and route information.

7. Medical aid requests are anticipated to flow from either the incident or a communications center to the Incident Communications Unit. They go from there to the EMS Branch Director, who prioritizes the request based on direction from the Incident Commander or Operations, and gives the assignment to the Medical Group Supervisor. The supervisor sends the

appropriate medical response to accomplish the mission. The task force communicates directly with Med-Com to determine the hospital location for their patient(s) and an approved safe route.

8. By agreement of the Orange County Fire Chiefs, all task forces that are staged in a mobilization center or deployed in an impact area will have Advanced Life Support (ALS) capability. This criterion can be met with either a medic engine or a unit that has paramedic assessment (PA) capability.
9. To facilitate this, the paramedic assessment protocol will be automatically activated by the Operational Area Coordinator at the time that agencies are advised of a Level Two activation anywhere in the County. This will be done as a part of the opening of the mobilization center.

H. Hazardous Materials Component

Incident Management:
Management of an incident involving chemical, biological, and nuclear warfare agents should be conducted in a manner similar to managing a conventional hazardous materials incident. Unique challenges may present themselves in many forms. These might include lack of specific information, multiple casualties, multiple fatalities, large scale crime scene, and direct attack on public facilities and personnel.
Incidents of this type will usually necessitate the response of multiple agencies from all levels of government. Aside from the immediate public safety concerns, parallel operations may be underway in the interest of national security and law enforcement. A unified command will be necessary to ensure the safety and effectiveness of all response efforts. All actions taken must be based on an acceptable level of risk with a high degree of benefit.

1. Terrorist Incidents:

Weapons of Mass Destruction (WMD), whether they be chemical, biological or nuclear: present a significant risk to the general public and first responders. Approach cautiously, yet understand that rapid intervention **MAY** be necessary to avoid high mortality rates. **Rapid emergency decontamination MAY be the single most important intervention the first responder can accomplish to minimize injury and reduce unnecessary death**. As a general rule, decontamination should not be undertaken unless there are patients who are symptomatic, have obvious signs of contamination, or have tested positive when checked by instruments. However, chemical agents such as vesicants, **most biological agents and radiological agents** can have a delayed effect. For incidents where there are no symptomatic patients, a threat

assessment must be accomplished prior to decontamination.

2. Chemical Incidents

Early recognition is the most important factor in identifying that a chemical agent has been used. Signs that should alert you to the possibility that a chemical agent has been used are:

Rapid incapacitation of victims.

a. A large number of victims. There may be hundreds or thousands of victims.

b. a large area of involvement. Though a WMD incident may be isolated to a small area, it may also encompass entire buildings, blocks, or cities.
c. Numerous victims with the same symptoms
d. The presence of a dissemination device.
e. Dead animals in the area.
f. Statements of victims
g. Witness statements and initial reports from witnesses.
h. That instinctual feeling “that things don’t fit”.

3. Biological Incidents

Biological weapons rely on bacteria, rickettsia, virus, toxin, and fungi to infect a host (people, plants, or animals) which cause illness, disease and death. Regardless of which agent is used, the onset of symptoms typically begin within 3-7 days after exposure and generally present as flu type symptoms. In rare cases, symptoms may begin as early as 1 day or be delayed as much as 3 weeks.

A biological release, unless identified at the time of the release by the person or group involved, will evidence itself only when a large number of victims exhibit symptoms of a disease not normally seen in the area. The nature of the biological incident may leave one or more areas contaminated with organisms or toxin. However, the persons infected will probably appear across a large geographical area as they disperse and begin to seek treatment in emergency rooms, urgent care centers, or private clinics.

a. Identification

Early recognition is the most important factor in identifying a WMD biological event. For threat assessment of suspected biological

agents refer to the wire charts (Appendix A). There are several signs that will alert you to the possibility of the involvement of biological agents. Included are:

1. A large epidemic with high illness or death rate.
2. Predominate respiratory symptoms in large numbers of people.
3. Infectious diseases in non-endemic areas.
4. Multiple spontaneous outbreaks.
5. Multi-drug-resistant pathogens
6. Sick or dead animals of multiple types.
7. That instinctual feeling “that things don’t fit”.

b. Site Control and Quarantine

Both strict site control and quarantine of suspected exposures are essential. Site control will limit the spread of the material and contamination. Quarantine of possible exposures will limit the spread of the disease.

It is essential that a complete and thorough risk analysis be performed prior to instituting decontamination or other procedures. Unlike a chemical incident, time is not a critical factor.

NOTE: Orange County Health Care Agency has the sole responsibility and authority to quarantine victims.

c. Notification and Evaluation

Early notification of health officials is critical. A quarantine must be considered if the disease produced by the agent is communicable. Generally, transporting a few patients away from the scene may be reasonable.

The facility to which these patients are being transported must be alerted, and the facility must be capable of isolating the patients when they arrive. When large numbers of exposures are involved, it may be useful to consider a quarantine at or near the incident site and then begin treatment.

When a biological agent is suspected, all exposed persons should be considered to be contagious and treated as such until a competent medical authority can evaluate the situation and circumstances and provide specific information and guidance.

NOTE: Orange County Health Care Agency has the sole responsibility and authority to quarantine victims.

d. Nuclear Incidents:

Radiation occurs in many forms, most of which are harmless. Examples of harmless natural forms of radiation include light, sound, and solar. For the purposes of this document, discussion will be limited to harmful radiation that is also known as ionizing radiation.

Ionizing radiation occurs when an electron is stripped from the atom. Ionizing radiation effects, the body in two ways; cell destruction occurs by changing H20 into H202 (water into Hydrogen Peroxide), which becomes toxic to the body, and results in DNA mutation. Cell destruction and DNA mutation occur at a rate proportionate to the amount of the radiation-absorbed dose (rad). Once exposure has taken place, cell destruction takes place rapidly. Depending on the type and amount of radiation, signs and symptoms may be immediate or may take 4-5 days or even longer to manifest. Where significant exposure has taken place, DNA mutation may effect multiple generations.

Classifications of ionizing radiation include alpha particles, beta particles, and gamma rays.

Early recognition is the most important factor in identifying a WMD nuclear / radiological event. With the exception of a known radiological facility such as a nuclear generating plant, or the presence of 704M labels on the side of a building, there are no outward signs to identify that radiological sources may be present. Confirmation that radiological materials are present must be made through radiological monitoring.

e. Radiation Exposure Levels

The Department of Energy and Nuclear Regulatory Commission have developed exposure guidelines for radiological workers. For exposure levels consult Orange County Health Department.

4. Management of the incident should be based on three steps:

a. Establishing and updating incident priorities.

1) Life Safety
2) Incident Stabilization
3) Property and Environmental Conservation
4) Investigation of Cause and Origin

b. Continual size-up of incident.
    1) Present Situation
    2) Predicted Behavior
c. Establishing and updating incident action plan.
    1) Strategic Goals
    2) Tactical Objectives
    3) Task Operations